

RESEARCH NOTE · PRESENTATION

The State of Counter-Strike

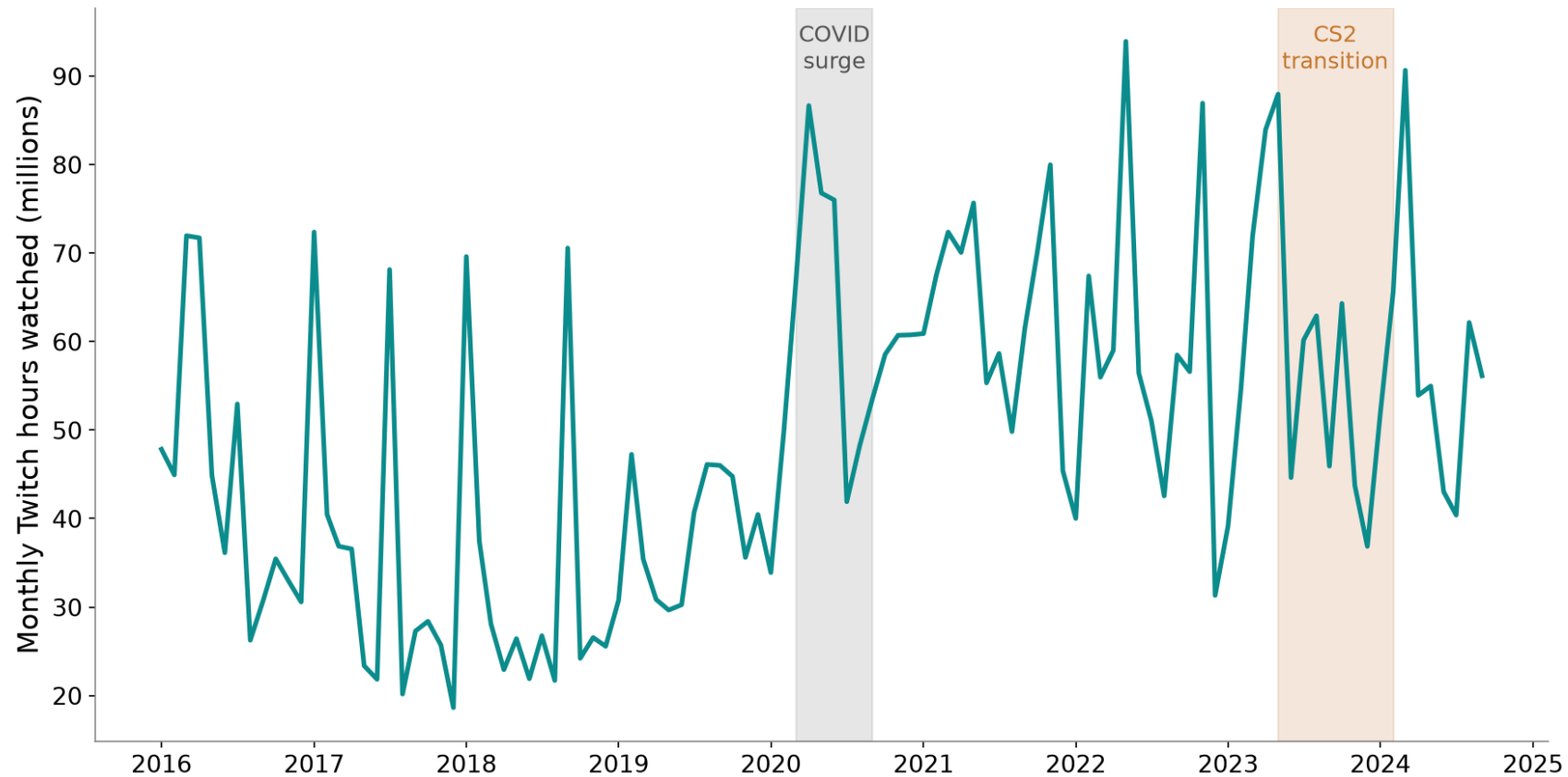
A ten-year view of growth, maturity, and where the ceiling might be.

11 September 2026

I.

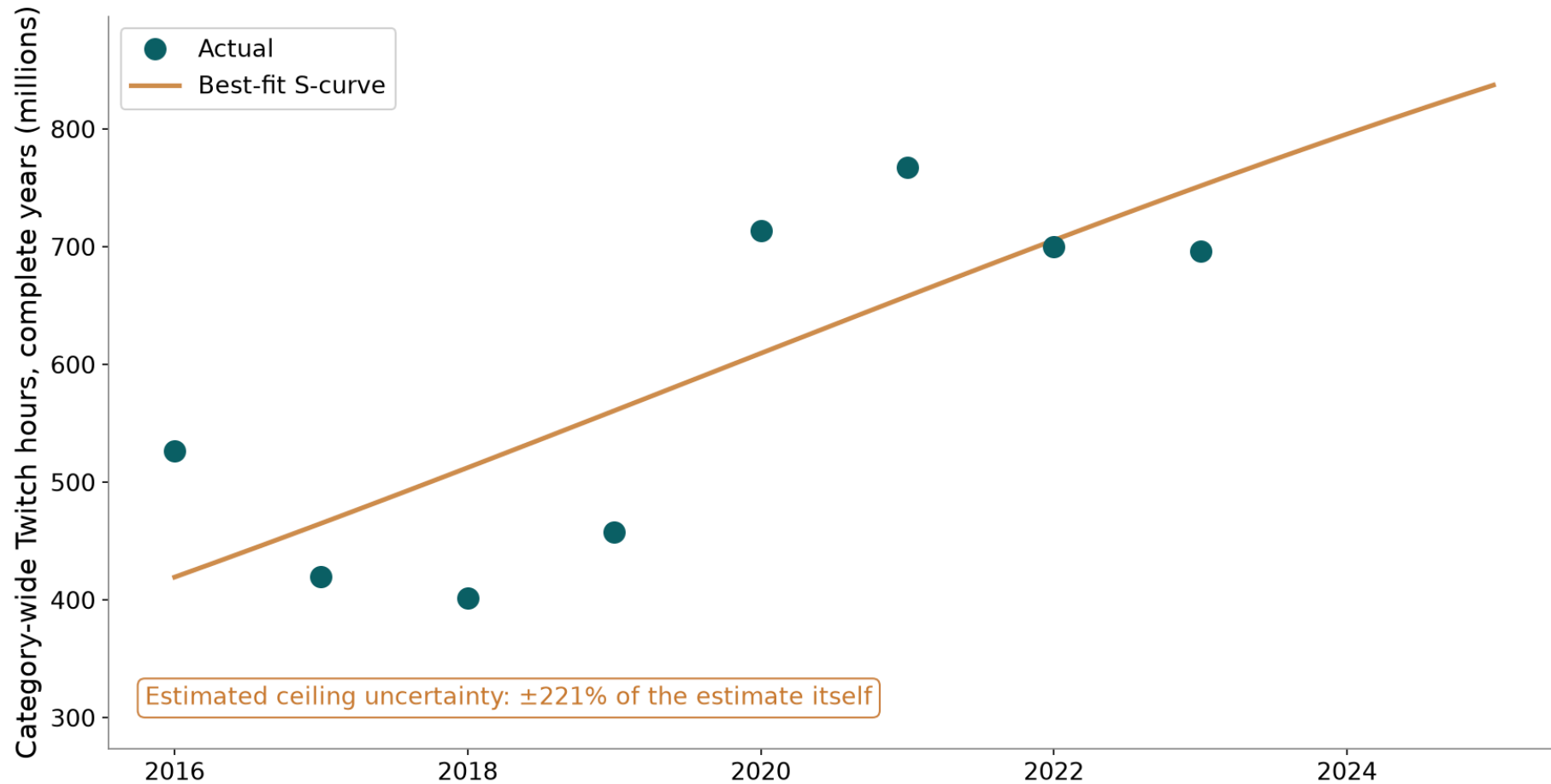
Is Counter-Strike Still Growing?

Twitch viewing hours have grown through repeated step-changes since 2016 — with a real shock around the 2023 engine transition, not a smooth climb toward a ceiling.



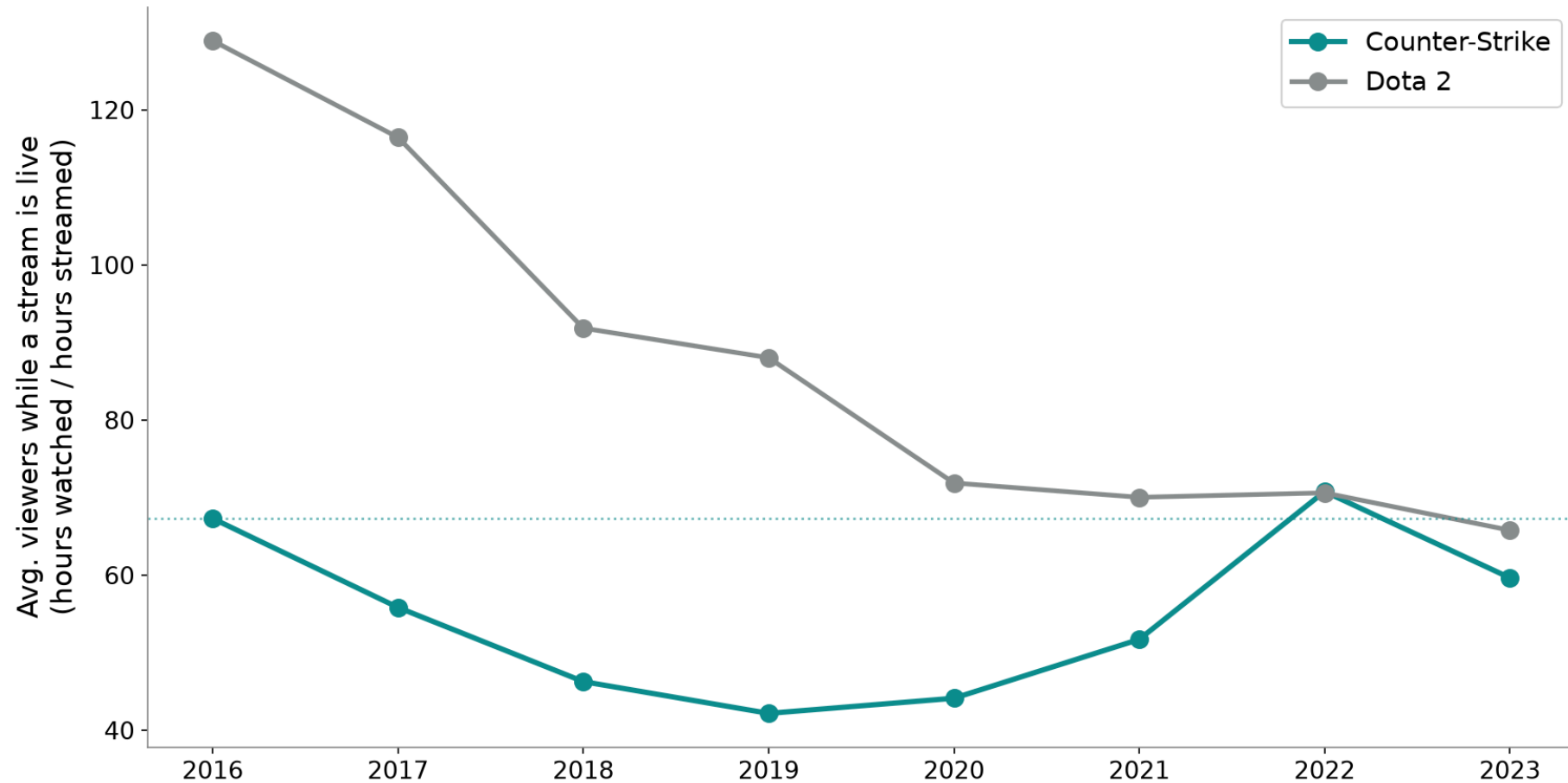
Monthly category-wide Twitch hours watched, all Counter-Strike. Source: a published historical Twitch dataset, 2016–2024.

A logistic growth-curve fit — the standard test for a market approaching saturation — fails outright: the model cannot even identify where a ceiling would be.



Best-fit S-curve against complete-year totals. The fitted ceiling's own uncertainty exceeds the estimate itself — shock-and-recovery, not smooth deceleration.

Per-stream audience depth — the cleanest read on genuine audience growth — recovered past its 2016 level by 2022. Dota 2's, over the same years, nearly halved.

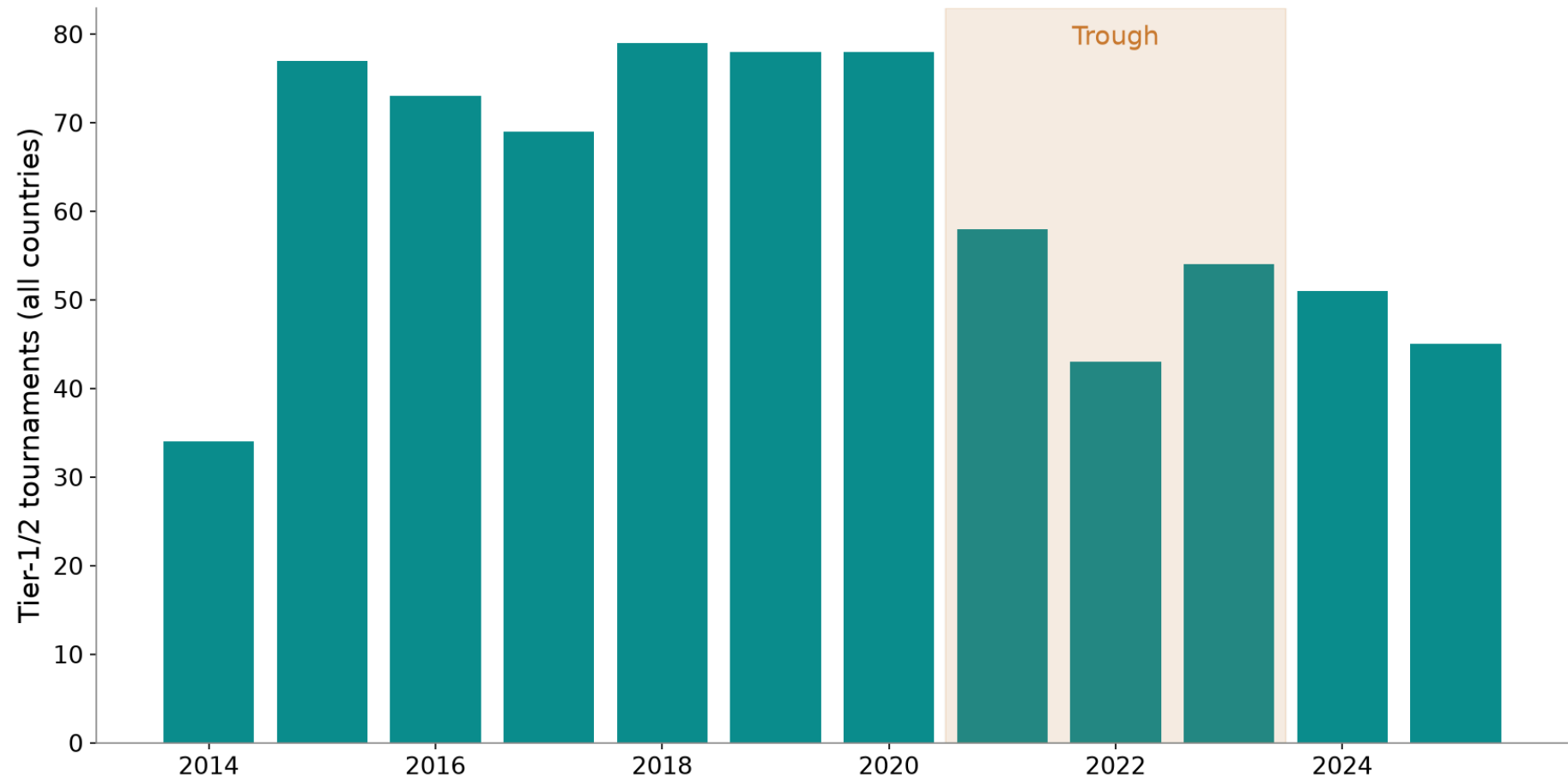


Hours watched ÷ hours streamed, by year. A rising total can come from more content airing rather than a bigger audience per broadcast; this metric separates the two.

II.

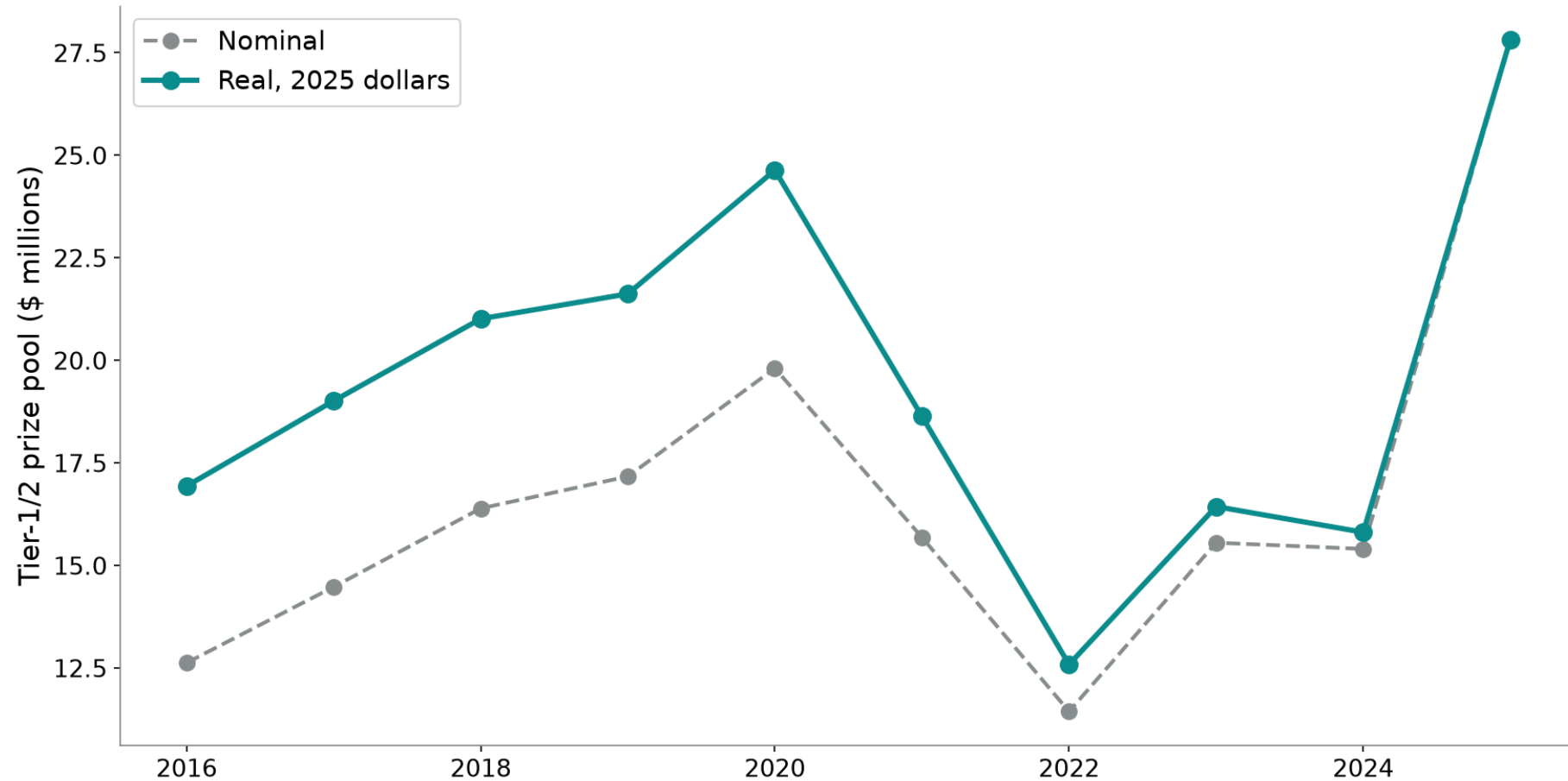
The Competitive Tier: Investment Up, Structure Narrowing

Tier-1/2 tournament count shows a real 2021–2023 trough that has only partially recovered.



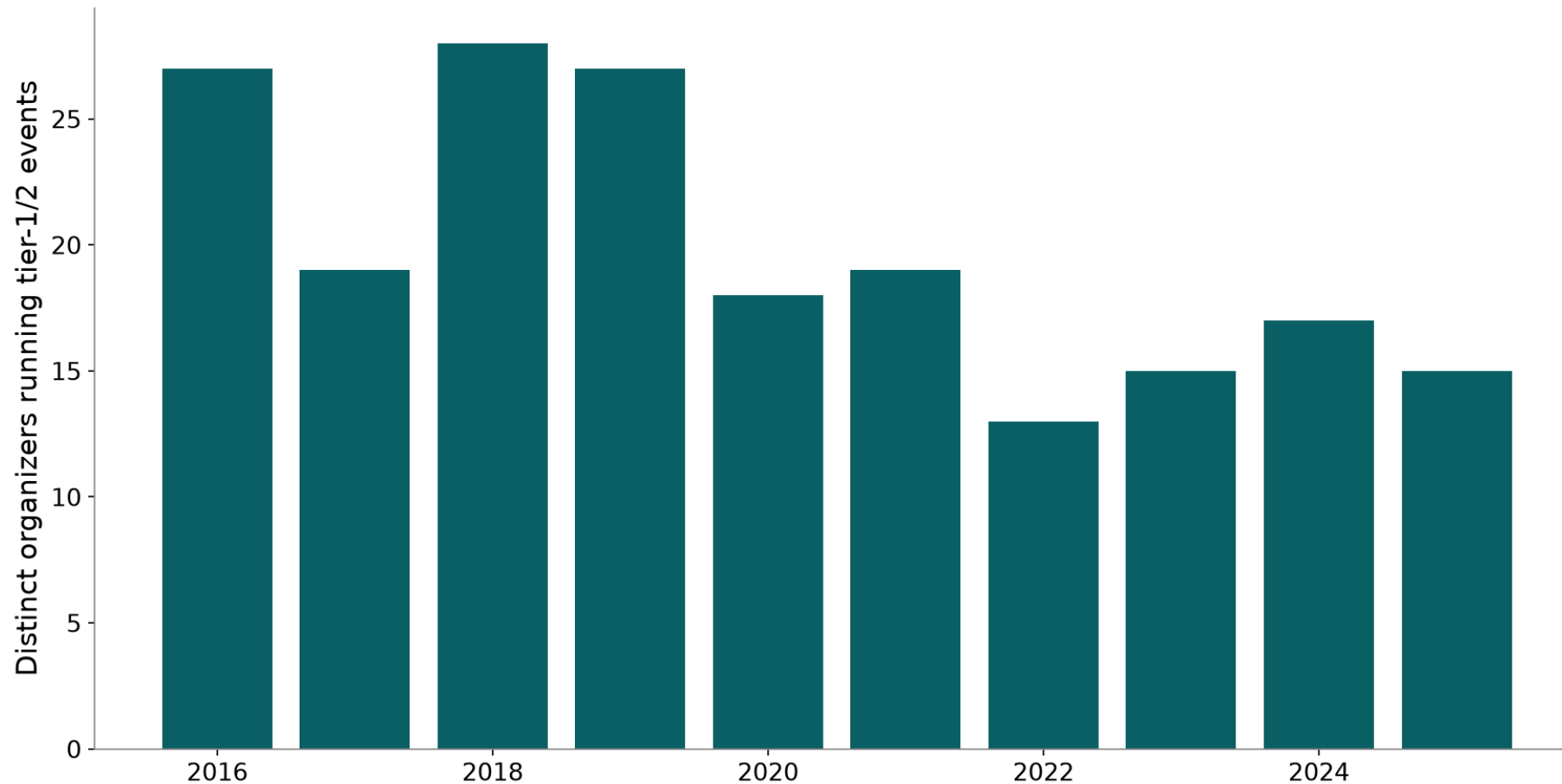
Top two competitive tiers, all countries, by year.

2025's real, inflation-adjusted prize pool is an all-time record — evidence of continued investment, not proof the sport's commercial value is growing.



USD-denominated tier-1/2 prize pool, nominal vs. CPI-deflated (2025 dollars).

That record is organizationally narrower than it looks: the number of distinct organizers running tier-1/2 events has fallen by nearly half since 2016.

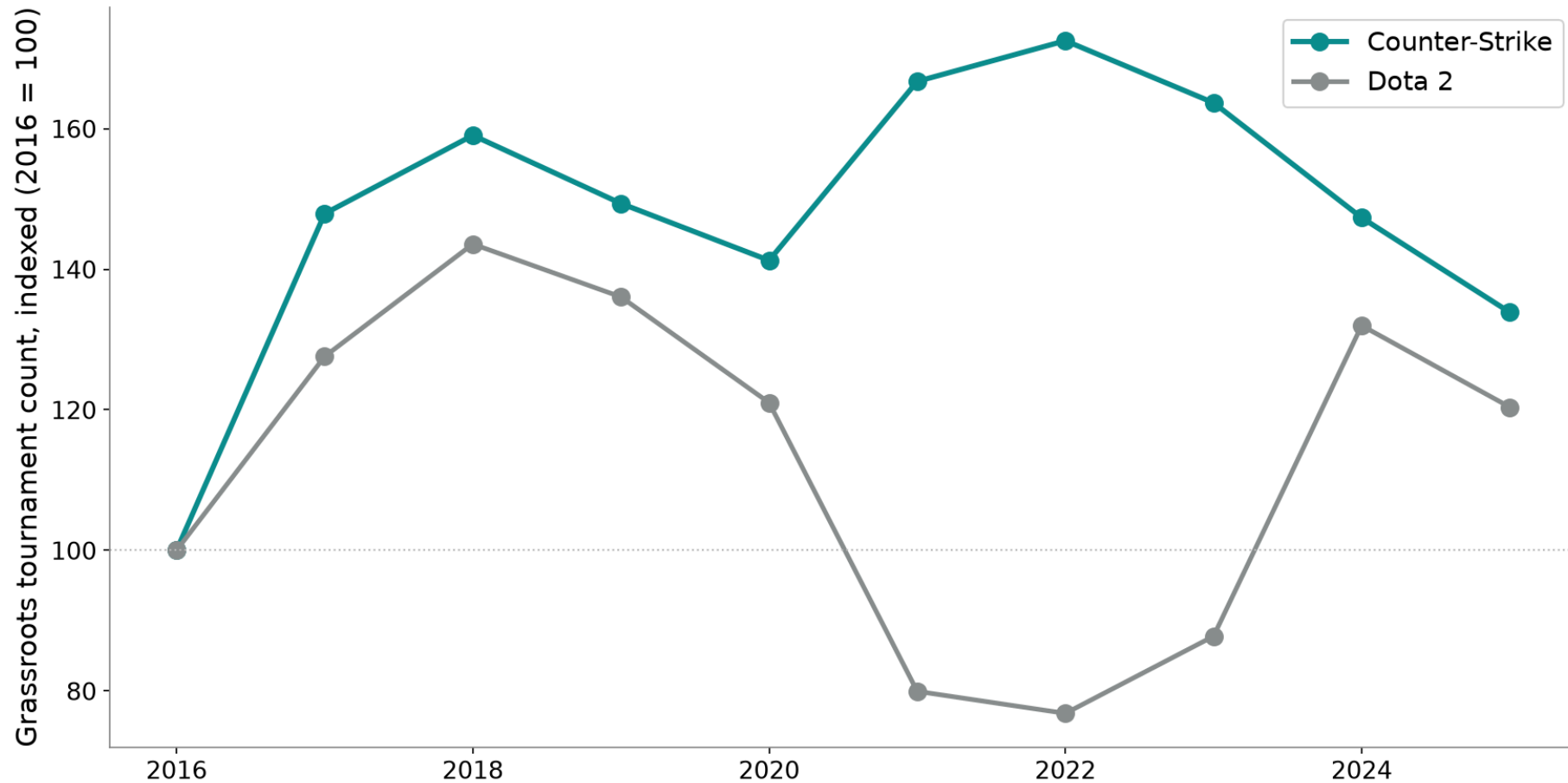


Distinct top-level tournament organizers per year, tier-1/2 events.

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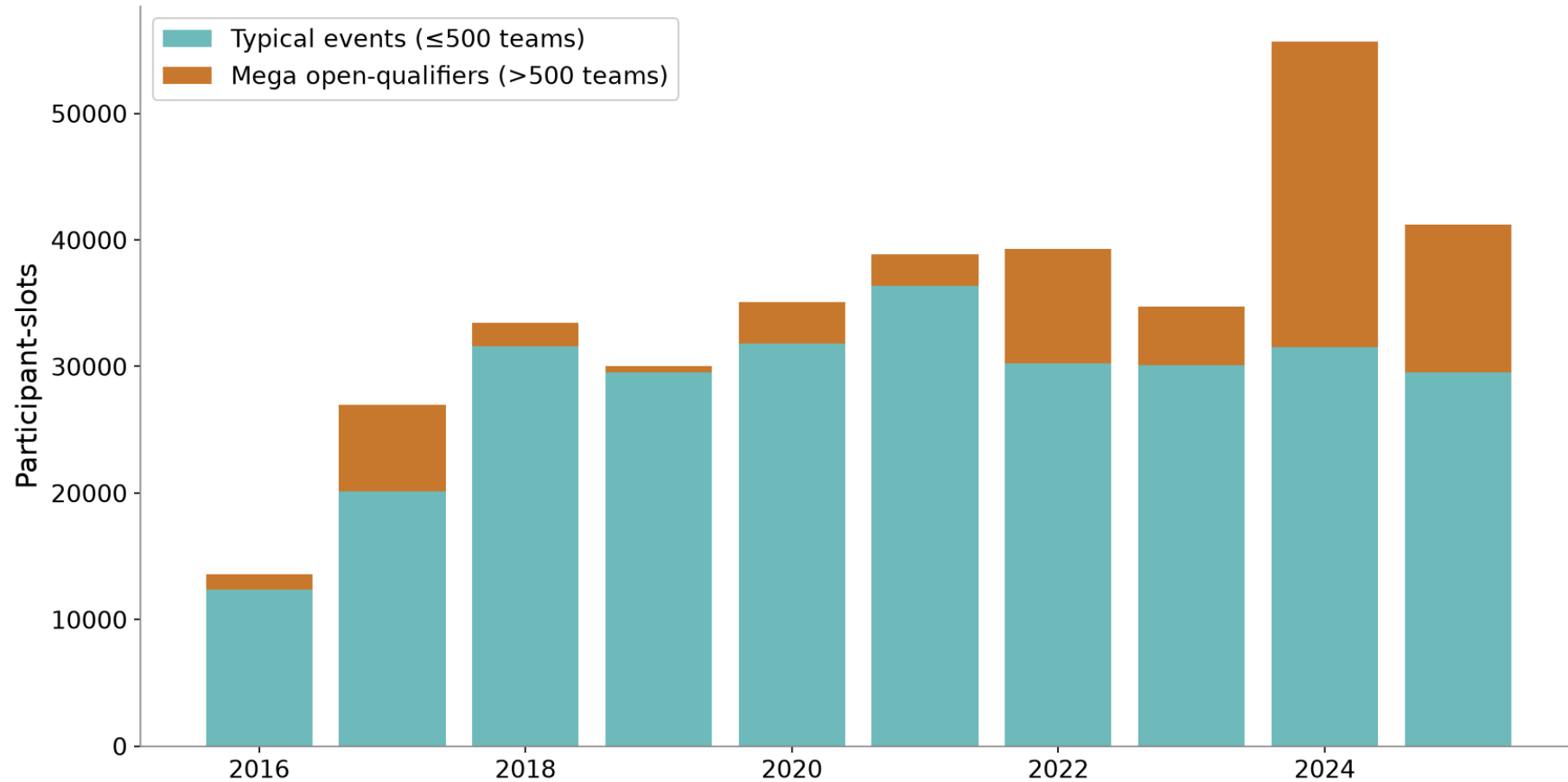
Grassroots: The Base of the Pyramid

The grassroots tier is narrowing too, for both Counter-Strike and Dota 2 — tournament counts have declined from a mid-cycle peak, not grown, through 2025.



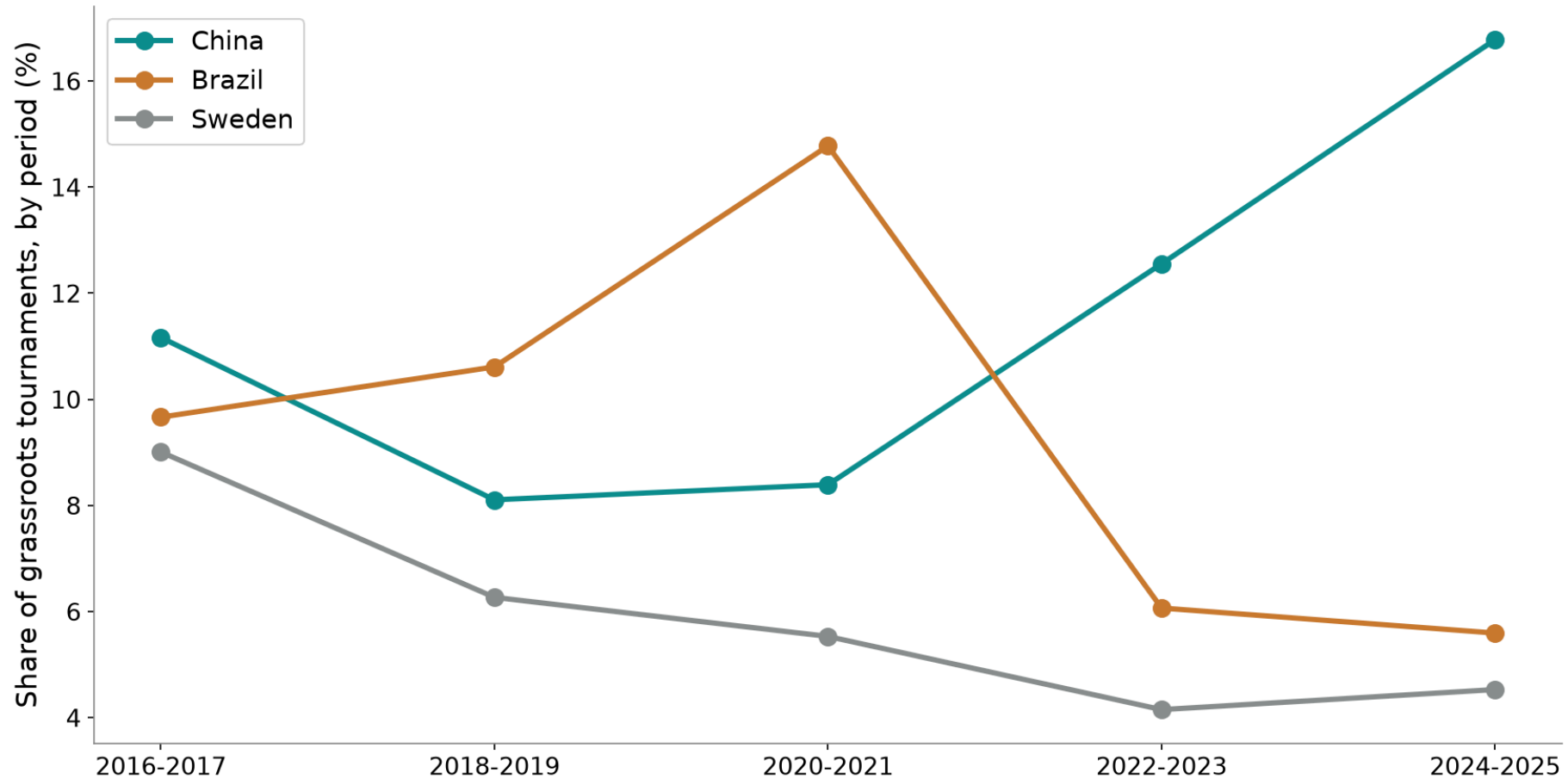
Grassroots (community-tier) tournament count, indexed to each title's own 2016 level.

But within Counter-Strike, typical participation and per-event scale are holding up even as tournament count falls — fewer events, not a broadly shrinking base.



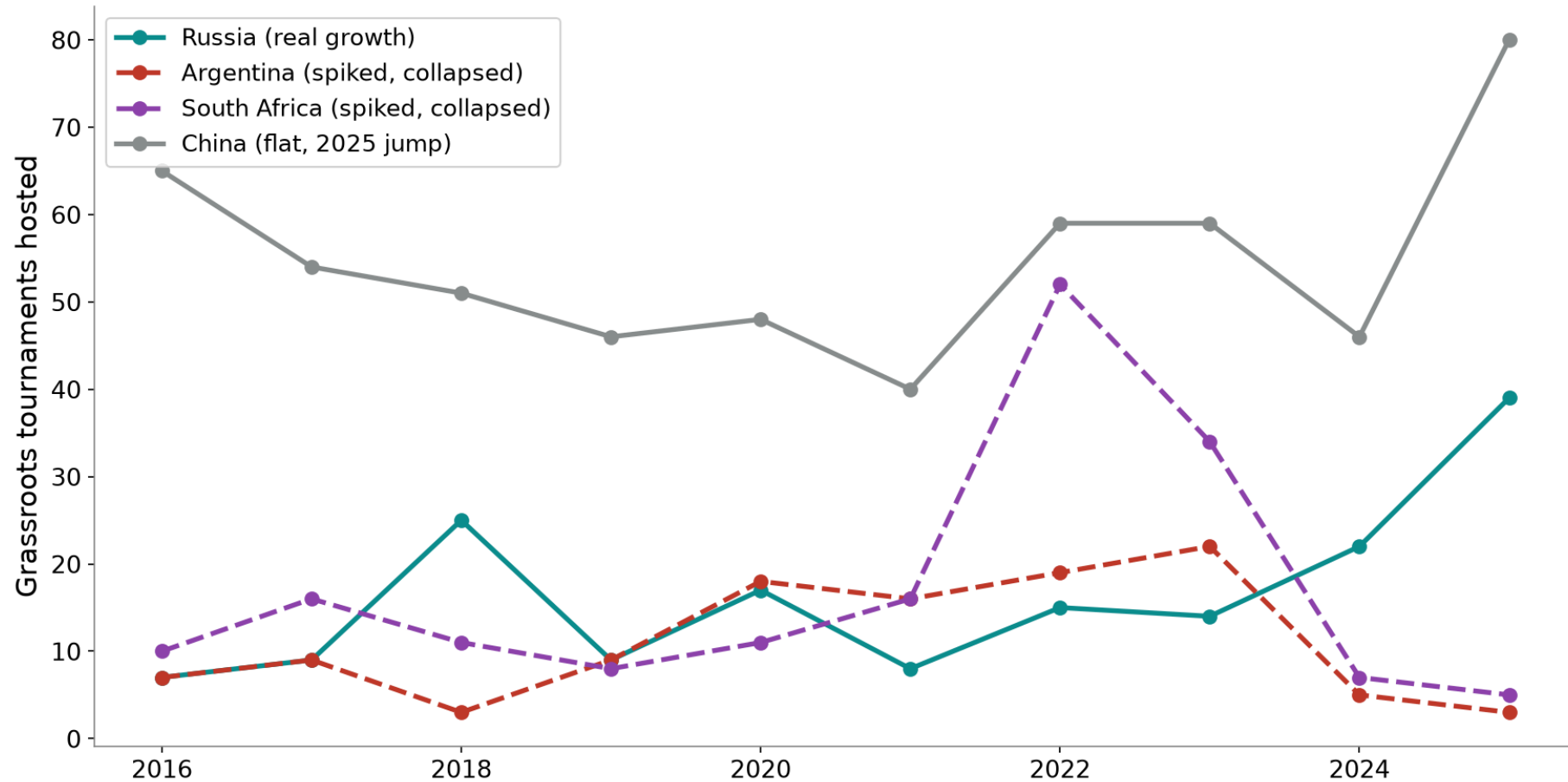
Grassroots participant-slots, split into typical events and occasional massive open-bracket qualifiers (China-concentrated).

Regional composition is shifting, not simply shrinking — China has grown into a clear #1 while Brazil's and Sweden's shares have eroded.



Share of grassroots tournaments by country, in two-year periods.

Once real year-by-year trajectories replace before/after snapshots, most apparent regional growth turns out to be a spike that already collapsed.

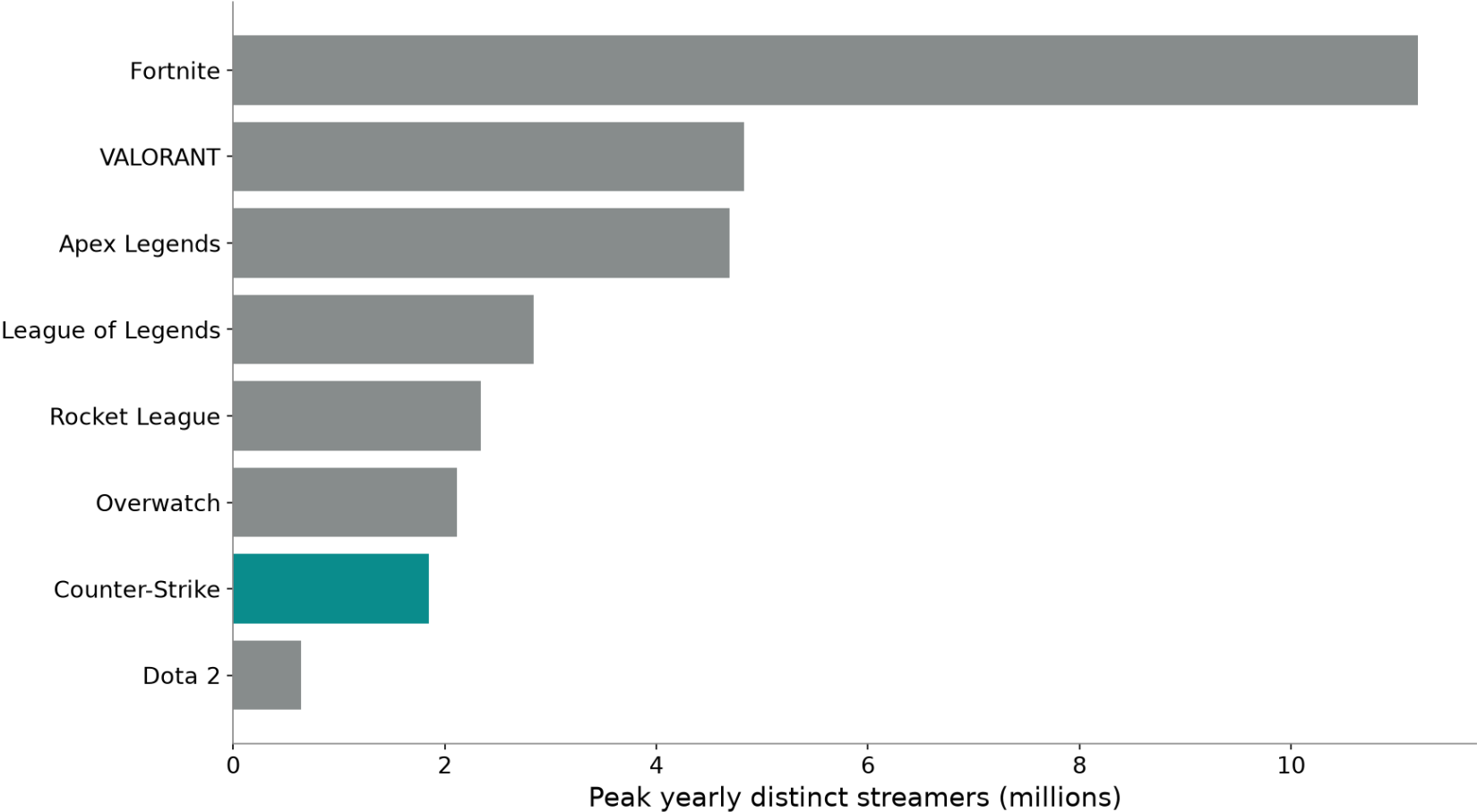


Argentina and South Africa both spiked in 2022–23 and have since fallen below their 2016 levels; Russia's growth is real and recent.

IV.

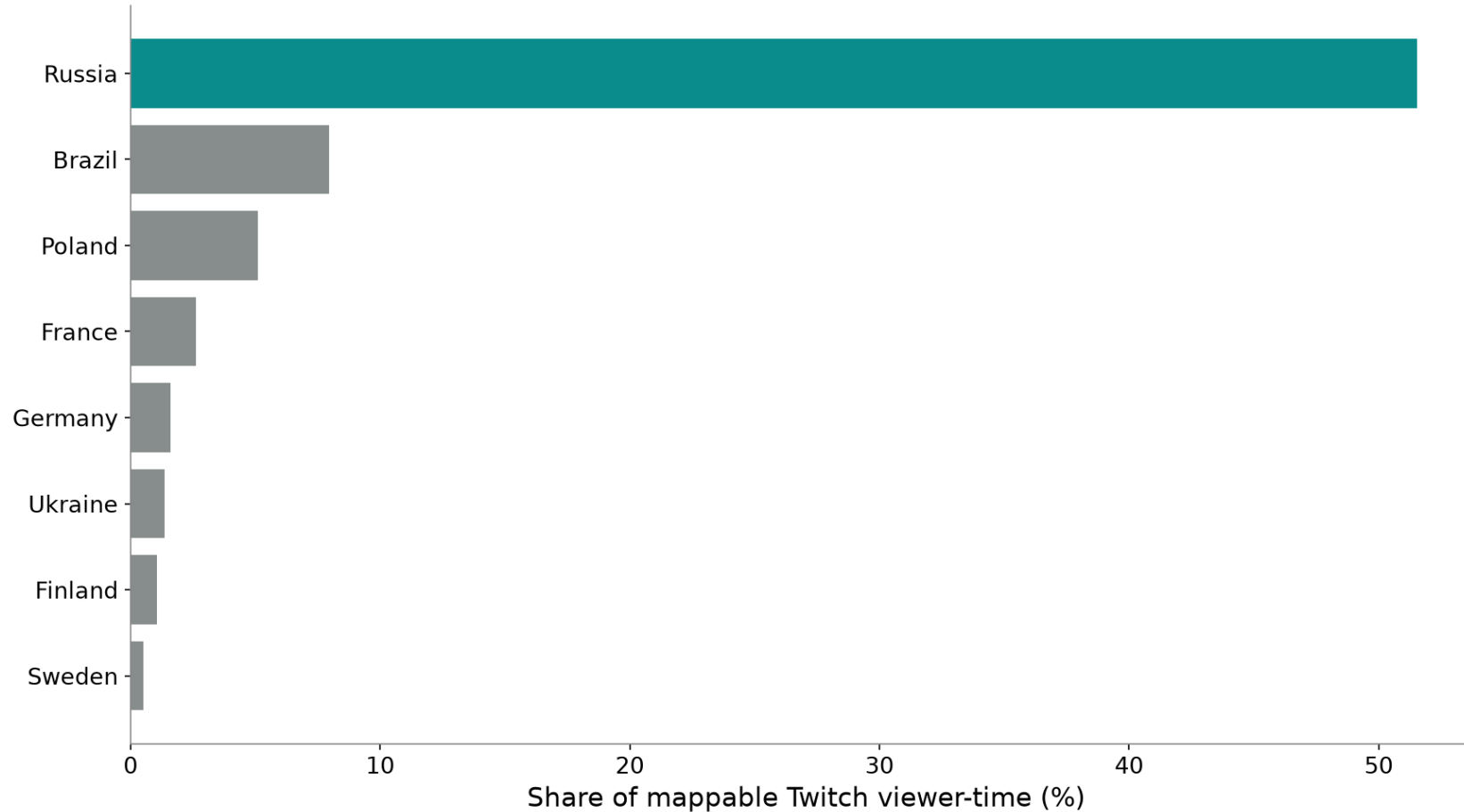
Creators and Audience

Counter-Strike's creator ecosystem has grown, but sits well below the size of the platform's newest mega-audience titles.



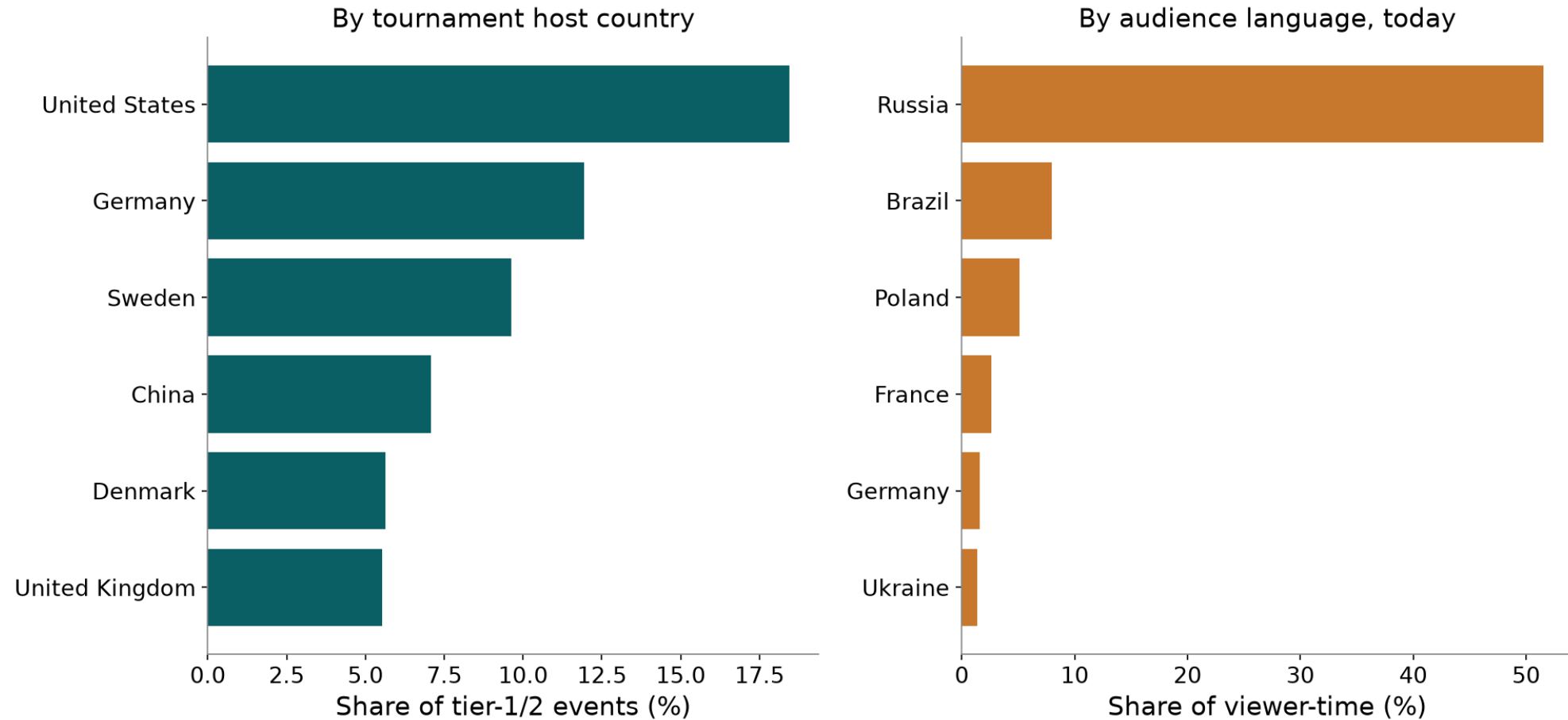
Peak yearly distinct streamers (summed monthly counts), 2016–2024. Source: a published historical Twitch dataset.

Audience geography remains heavily concentrated, not diversifying — over half of all mappable Counter-Strike viewing on Twitch is Russian-language.



Current snapshot only — Twitch's live-only API cannot show a historical trend here.

Where tournaments are hosted and where the audience actually is do not even agree with each other.

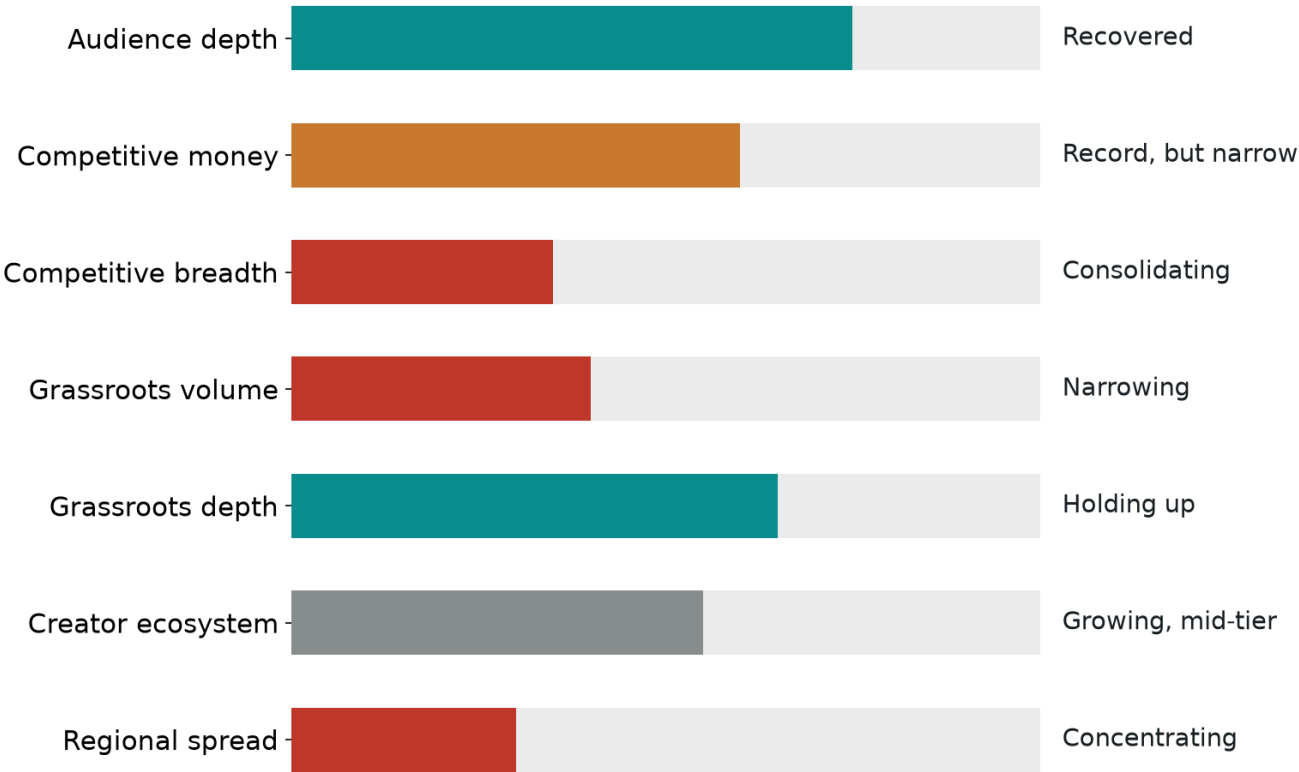


Left: tier-1/2 tournament host country. Right: current audience language share, mapped to country.

v.

**So — Is Counter-Strike a Mature,
Saturated Market?**

Not in the sense of smooth deceleration — but growth, where it exists, has become narrower: fewer organizers, fewer grassroots events, more concentrated regions and audiences.



A qualitative summary of the preceding sections, not a new measurement.

Sources

- **Live viewership and audience language.** Twitch's own public API, polled by this project's collectors.
- **Historical viewing and streamer counts.** A published historical dataset of Twitch category viewing hours, 2016–2024.
- **Tournaments, prize pools, and organizers.** Twitch's public tournament-and-team wiki.
- **Inflation adjustment.** U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics CPI data (FRED), 2025 dollars.